



HUMANITAS
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Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Rockbridge Academy
School Website: <https://www.rockbridge.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Rockbridge Academy in Maryland (Rockbridge Academy (Crownsville, MD, 21032)) presents a robust Classical Christian education profile, anchored in a distinctly Christian metaphysical framework, a virtue- and formation-centered purpose, a classical curriculum, traditional pedagogy aligned with the Trivium, a faculty that embodies the school's mission, and a strong, ongoing partnership with families. Public-facing materials consistently emphasize Christ-centered formation, truth-goodness-beauty as real and knowable, an integrated liberal-arts curriculum, and a leadership emphasis on rhetoric, public speaking, and classical discourse. The Paideia School extension and several faculty/staff narratives reinforce the model of parents as co-educators and the university-model/Hybrid approach to home-based learning in partnership with a classical classroom. Taken together, Rockbridge Academy (Crownsville, MD, 21032) aligns overwhelmingly with the Six Essential Elements of Classical Education and earns an overall CLASSICAL rating.

Key signals include: explicit statements that education is formation in a Christian framework (not merely information) and that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and to be pursued; a curriculum built on grammar, logic, and rhetoric, integration of history and the liberal arts, and attention to great books and classical texts; pedagogy that blends contemplative/ memory-based practices (lower grades) with Socratic/seminar-style inquiry and rhetorical training (upper grades); a faculty described in terms of mentorship and character formation; and an active partnership with parents, including models like The Paideia School that explicitly situate parents as co-educators.

Evidence and analysis drawn from Rockbridge's public-facing site and school materials are anchored by these sources, including explicit mission statements, curricular descriptions, and pedagogy notes. Citations reflect representative material from the Rockbridge site and the classical-education Rubric documents in the knowledge base. See citations throughout for traceability.

- Evidence of Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Rockbridge frames education as Christ-centered and the curriculum as theological in scope; theology is woven through every subject; worship and communal faith formation are foregrounded.
- Evidence of School Purpose and Goal: Rockbridge describes its mission as forming thinking Christians, modeling virtue and wisdom, and pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty in all life.
- Evidence of Curriculum: The Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration of history and Great Books/new-ancient-text approach, and a Grand Tour/Great-Books orientation appear in multiple passages, with explicit references to Latin and classical texts.
- Evidence of Pedagogy: Public materials show lower-school memory/chanting and high-school Socratic/seminar rhetoric, along with opportunities for speeches and debate. The Paideia School model (two days on campus, three at home) is explicitly described.
- Evidence of Faculty: Narratives emphasize teachers as living curriculum, mentorship, and character formation, with multiple posts illustrating faculty leadership, guidance, and a culture of virtue.

- Evidence of Parents & Community: The mission explicitly highlights parental partnership and the Paideia School as a pathway for co-educators; website materials invite parent involvement and provide pathways for parents to engage with the classical project.

Overall, Rockbridge Academy (Crownsville, MD, 21032) demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories, with strong corroboration in the core elements of a classical Christian school: transcendental truths via a Christian metaphysical frame; formation-first aims; a Trivium-based curriculum; contemplative and dialectic pedagogy; a living, virtuous faculty; and a robust, partnership-driven parents/community framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence: Christ-centered framing; the Scriptures as central; communal worship; theology as integrated into daily life and coursework. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; imago Dei; worship; reverence; Logos; wisdom. Negative signals (as per lexicon) are mostly absent in public-facing materials. Estimated positive keyword presence well above negative. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The site repeatedly ties education to truth, virtue, and worship; theology saturates coursework; liturgical and communal practices are present.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence: Mission to form virtue and wisdom; education as formation (not mere information); pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty; emphasis on human flourishing and moral imagination. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, scholé, great conversation, telos, and moral imagination. Negative indicators (e.g., job-readiness) are not the focus. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The school foregrounds formation and the teleological pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, not solely career prep.
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence: Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric); history across the curriculum; Great Books/primary sources; Grand Tour-inspired study; Latin root words; integration with theology. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include seven liberal arts/trivium, great books, primary sources, Western civilization, and classical languages; integration and unity of truth across subjects. Negative indicators (per lexicon) are not prominent in public materials. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The curriculum emphasizes the liberal-arts core, classical texts, integrated study, and languages, aligning with classical norms.
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL Evidence: Contemplative/restful elements in parts of pedagogy; memory and recitation in lower grades; Socratic discussion/seminars in upper years; rhetoric training and public speaking; Paideia/Home-Education hybrid model. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include Socratic dialogue, memorization, liturgical/recitation practices, seminar, rhetoric, and public speaking; some project-based/experiential trends are present in Paideia, but the core pedagogy remains classical. Negative indicators (per lexicon) such as exclusive reliance on experiential learning are not dominant. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The site demonstrates a clear mix of contemplative, memory-based pedagogy and high-level rhetoric/seminar work, with a formal path from grammar to rhetoric.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence: Teachers described as mentors/model virtuous living; living curriculum; faculty as core community; collaboration and mentorship among staff and students; portrait/expectations of teachers. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include master/mentor roles, living curriculum, collegial culture, and character formation; limited explicit negative signals in described faculty. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The materials emphasize teachers as moral exemplars and central to the curriculum, consistent with classical tradition.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Explicit partnership with parents; parental formation/education through book/gatherings; Paideia School as parent-led collaborative model; open invitations for parent involvement; two-days-on-campus/three-days-at-home model illustrating active parental participation. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include parent partnership, co-educators, family involvement, household rhythms, and home-centered learning; negative

signals (e.g., consumerism, minimal parent involvement) are not dominant in the public-facing materials. Category rating: CLASSICAL. Why: The school explicitly positions parents as co-educators and features programs that require active parental engagement in the learning process.

Aggregate assessment Rockbridge Academy (Crownsville, MD, 21032) is CLASSICAL across all six categories, with evidence of deep integration of a Christian metaphysical frame, a formation-centered purpose, a Trivium-based curriculum, classical pedagogy (Socratic/seminar work and rhetorical training), a living-faculty model, and an active, partnered parent community. The balance of explicit mission statements, curricular descriptions, and pedagogy notes demonstrates consistent adherence to classical principles in the Six Essential Elements framework.

What would move the needle - Not applicable (no category is rated SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL). No major needle-moving changes appear necessary to reach a full CLASSICAL rating, given the robust alignment across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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